Striking a Universal CHORD

AUTHOR-SINGER **AMIT CHAUDHURI** IS BACK WITH A NEW ALBUM AFTER 13 YEARS



Readers probably know of Amit Chaudhuri as a writer par excellence, with eight novels, four non-fiction books, a poetry collection and a host of well-cited studies and essays to his credit. But the 60-year-old multi-hyphenate also has a sideline in music, dating all the way back to when he was a 17-year-old high school student writing and performing English songs on All India Radio. He trained in Indian classical singing under his mother Bijoya Chaudhuri and the late Pandit Govind Prasad Jaipurwale of the Kunwar Shyam *gharana*, releasing recordings of Indian classical and *khayal*.

In 2004, Chaudhuri embarked on an ambitious, long-running experiment in what he called 'not fusion'—a project of finding serendipitous confluences and convergences between the classical and semi-classical music of his homeland and the jazz, pop and rock canons of the West. His first two albums under this rubric—*This Is Not Fusion* (2007) and *Found Music* (2010)—featured re-imagined renditions of classics like George Gershwin's "Summertime", The Beatles' "Norwegian Wood" and Eric Clapton and Jim Gordon's "Layla", as Chaudhuri attempted to find the raga in the rock-and-roll backbeat.

"This project began with me hearing the riff to "Layla" in Raag Todi as I was singing Todi," remembers Chaudhuri. "This was in 2004. I began to explore the idea of improvising on the *raga* via the riff, using certain common notes that made that possible. I have begun to call them transition notes—sounds shared by two systems and pieces of music that allow you to move from one piece to the other."

After 13 years of relative silence, Chaudhuri returns to the project with his new album *Across the Universe*, released on February 7. He had been performing the older songs—and writing new ones—in the meantime, but academic and writing commitments and the itinerant careers of his band members kept him away from the studio. In July 2022, a year after he took early retirement from the University of East Anglia, perhaps inspired by the research for his award-winning music history-cum-memoir *Finding the Raga*—he travelled to Norwich and re-assembled his English band for a couple of days in the studio.



Live recordings give the album's five tracks a loose, improvisational feel

"I knew I would be going to England, so I let the musicians I had performed with over there know that I wanted to record these